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Dialogue on racial tension opens as UT students, president meet

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Black Student Alliance members met with the president of the University of Texas on Thursday - the first such meeting since two UT fraternities were accused of racist acts. But the students left the meeting with "no new plans of action and no new commitments."

"The role they took is not supportive, at least in the direct fashion, of our proposal" for multicultural education, said Marcus Brown, president of the student organization.

"There were no new plans of action and no new commitments. It was basically the same traditional rhetoric. But they have agreed to dialogue in the future, so hopefully we can get the university to take a more supportive position."

UT President William Cunningham and members of Brown's organization were joined by other high-level administrators, Students' Association President Toni Luckett and representatives of Asian, Mexican American and graduate student-employee organizations.

Charges of racism against two fraternities earlier this month sparked almost daily demonstrations on campus. Both fraternities have been temporarily suspended.

During Thursday's meeting, administrators said Sharon Justice, dean of students, would have a decision on the fraternities' fate next week.

After the incidents, students with the Black Student Alliance presented a plan called Project PRIDE (Proposed Reforms to Institute Diversity in Education) outlining ways to diversify the campus, including recruiting more black professors and requiring at least one African American studies class for all undergraduate students.

James Vick, vice president of student affairs, said Cunningham and the students discussed several issues and looked over the Project PRIDE proposal. He called the meeting a "healthy exchange."

Cunningham did not comment to the press. He later issued a statement that said the meeting was "open and frank. I hope it will lead to a continuing dialogue regarding racial issues at the university."

Brown said the black student organization, created in 1982, will keep the issue alive and plans to bring supporters from the state Legislature, UT faculty and community to future meetings.

He said the student groups tried to pin down Cunningham on when the Black Student Alliance and the president could meet again, but could not.

"His position was one of neutrality," Brown said. "We wanted him to take a leadership role."

Earlier Thursday, a new group on campus called Todos Unidos (Everyone United) gathered in the rain on the South Mall to show their support for the Black Student Alliance and demand that UT also heed the plight of Mexican American students.

A platform outlined by Todos Unidos calls for:

Increased recruitment and retention efforts of Mexican American students and faculty.

More support for the Center for Mexican American Studies.

Diversification of the curriculum, including requiring all undergraduate students to take at least one Mexican American Studies course.

UT statistics show that about 3 percent of the school's 2,200 faculty members are Hispanic and 11 percent of the school's 51,000 students are Hispanic.

Earlier this week, Lockett and Brown declined to talk about the racial climate on campus with Nancy Ferrell, a federal mediator with the U.S. Department of Justice who visited UT's campus Wednesday.

"I don't see the U.S. Justice Department as an impartial mediator" or what Ferrell could do to soothe racial conflicts on campus, Lockett said. "She asked if she could help. And I said no."

The BSA's Brown sent Ferrell a letter saying his attorney advised him not to talk to her.

"Our agency has spent a lifetime" dealing with racial disputes and can offer insights on ways to cope, Ferrell said. "If I felt like our involvement would minimize the concerns of students . . . (and) the administration, we would not be living up to our obligation."

UT Students' Association President Toni Lockett, left, joins Enrique Torres Thursday at a gathering of a new Hispanic student group, Todos Unidos. AP

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